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Research Topic: Artificial Intelligence and Labor Markets: A Narrative Review of Expected Effects and Policy Responses in California and South Korea

Title: Artificial Intelligence and Labor Markets: A Narrative Review of Expected Effects and Policy Responses in California and South Korea

Research Problem

Artificial Intelligence (AI) is penetrating work environments more rapidly than any prior general-purpose technology, and the debate regarding its implications for employment has far outstripped the evidence capable of resolving it. The global investments into AI are setting new records [1], while according to employer surveys run by the World Economic Forum, structural changes are likely to generate 170 million and destroy 92 million jobs by 2030 [2]. Numbers such as these are being circulated as if they describe observed phenomena, while they are actually hypothetical scenarios built upon employers' expectations.

What the field suffers from is not the lack of evidence, but the lack of an organizing framework for interpreting it. Indeed, the existing literature includes at least five types of evidence answering different questions: exposure estimates, surveys of AI adoption, usage data from platforms, field experiments assessing causal effects of adoption in one particular work application, and payroll studies of employment and wages. Each of those pieces of evidence is being cited alongside other ones, even though they answer different questions and are at different stages of the same process. An estimate of exposure suggesting that only slightly above 46 percent of US jobs are capable of having a substantial portion of their tasks affected once the necessary complementaries are taken into account [4] is often cited alongside the evidence based on Danish administrative data demonstrating no observable changes in wages and hours [9], inviting a comparison of these as conflicting evidence, when in reality, they answer different questions.

The uncertainty about the risks associated with artificial intelligence also has its costs. Each of the few labor market policies targeting AI, which are currently operational, have been adopted over the past two years and have not yet generated data about their effectiveness. Therefore, the choice of governments adopting the instruments will be either between waiting for the data, which will only appear many years later, or applying estimates whose evidentiary basis cannot be determined with certainty. The initial results of outcomes show that the pressure is unevenly distributed as is discussed in the public debate. The payroll data from the USA reveal the relative employment reduction of roughly 13% of the workforce aged 22 to 25 in highly exposed occupations starting late 2022 with no comparable decline observed among the older workforce in the same occupation [8]. At the same time, the field experiment in the customer support industry revealed that a generative AI assistant increased productivity mostly of entry-level and less-skilled employees [6]. Neither of the cases does not correspond to the assumption that the displacement risk is uniform across the less-skilled employees while the highly skilled employees benefit from AI.

The need for research is immediate. The gap that needs to be filled is that of synthesis of the existing studies that would classify the evidence by the metrics, specify which elements of the conventional policy argument are backed up by evidence and which are still speculative, and evaluate the adequacy of risks targeted by the instruments currently being adopted.

Existing Literature

There are four related literatures on this topic, which are seldom juxtaposed. First, studies of potential impacts. In a model-based forecasting exercise, Acemoglu provides a conservative estimate for technical potential of not more than 0.66 percent additional contribution to total factor productivity per decade due to current technologies [3]; the International Monetary Fund shows that 60 percent of jobs in advanced countries are exposed to AI compared to 26 percent in developing nations [5]; Eloundou et al. find high task-level exposure among well-paid knowledge occupations based on language model capacity [4]; and Autor et al. argue based on historical precedent that new technology generates new occupations, conditional on a policy intervention that steers automation towards complementary tasks [12]. Second, measurement of adoption and use. According to the OECD survey of employers and workers, the most common effect so far is occupation-level task restructuring rather than occupation disappearance [10]. Third, empirical findings. Brynjolfsson, Li, and Raymond find experimentally that productivity gains are especially pronounced for less experienced workers [6]; Hui, Reshef, and Zhou find fewer contracts and lower pay for exposed freelancers in an online platform [7]; Brynjolfsson, Chandar, and Chen find the payroll association mentioned above [8]; and Humlum and Vestergaard do not find any effects on employment in Danish data [9]. Additionally, Hampole et al. point out that internal allocation of tasks can partially compensate for the fall in demand for exposed tasks at the occupation level [11]. Fourth, literature on governance. Using a model of transformative technology with gradually growing harm, Acemoglu and Lensman show that waiting until the diffusion is over to intervene is too costly [13]; after reviewing the policy and academic literature, Comunale and Manera argue that regulatory approaches are diverse while employment evidence is inconclusive [14]; Beraja et al. prove that governance framework is not politically neutral [15]; and the International Labour Organization shows that workers who are equally exposed in low-income countries enjoy much lower social protection [16].

Three gaps still remain. First, no review currently analyzes this literature by kind of evidence, meaning that there are ongoing comparisons between predictions about technical potential and actual results despite the fact that the two kinds of evidence are incomparable. Second, none of the policy reviews, even the most extensive one [14], was performed after the implementation of the 2025 and 2026 instruments mentioned below, including the California Civil Rights Council's regulations regarding automated-decision

systems [17], the upcoming No Robo Bosses Act of 2026 [18], and the Korean AI+ Competency-Up Project and Basic Plan for Industrial Transition Employment Stability [19], [20]. Third, no review has compared an instrument that regulates the process of deployment with one that provides funding for adjustments. The latter two are the only kinds of instruments that are represented by the provisions regulating AI usage in the EU AI Act [21] and the retraining literature.

Research Question

Central research question:

> To what extent does the current empirical evidence support the claim that the labor-market effects of AI are already uneven enough to justify preparing targeted policy responses now, and how closely do the design choices of two frontier jurisdictions, California and South Korea, correspond to the risks that this evidence identifies?

The question is deliberately narrow in what it asks to be demonstrated. It asks whether the evidence justifies preparation, not whether any instrument has been shown to work. That second question cannot be answered at present, because no AI-specific labor instrument has published outcome data. Four subsidiary questions structure the argument:

- **SQ1.** Which categories of workers are associated with which effects, and do observed patterns follow the skill gradient that public debate assumes?
- **SQ2.** What do the available forecasts and exposure estimates actually measure, how far do their magnitudes diverge, and which of them rest on observed rather than modeled data?
- **SQ3.** Does the pace of AI adoption relative to the pace of policymaking justify acting before displacement effects are measurable, and on what formal grounds?
- **SQ4.** Which risks does each jurisdiction address and which does it leave uncovered, and which design principles, as distinct from specific instruments, appear portable to jurisdictions with different legal powers and administrative capacity?

Scope conditions shall be mentioned clearly in the review. Any statements that involve the law and government program shall state the position up until a certain cut-off date of information. The comparison between the two jurisdictions will only deal with the design and implementation because both the subnational regulator and the national government have different powers and capacities.

Methodology

The review will be conducted according to a written protocol and take the form of a narrative review. The rationale for the choice of narrative rather than meta-analytic review methodology is that the pertinent studies employ incompatible outcome variables, units of analysis, and methods of identification. Any pooling of the exposure index, the

earnings regression at the platform level, and the administrative payroll data in terms of a measure of effect would yield numbers meaningless in their combination.

Source identification

- Academic databases and repositories: Google Scholar, ScienceDirect, JSTOR, the NBER and SSRN working-paper series, and journal archives in economics and public policy.

- Institutional repositories: OECD iLibrary, IMF publications, ILO working papers, World Economic Forum reports, and the Stanford AI Index.

- Primary legal and governmental sources: California Legislative Information, the Office of the Governor of California, the California Civil Rights Council, the California Privacy Protection Agency, and the Ministry of Employment and Labor of the Republic of Korea, including Korean-language releases.

- Reputable press coverage, used only to date events and to record budgetary figures announced but not yet published in official documents, and always identified as such.

Search strings will combine a technology term ("artificial intelligence", "generative AI", "large language models", "automated decision systems", "algorithmic management") with a labor term ("labor market", "employment", "wages", "occupational exposure", "displacement", "reskilling", "retraining") and, for the policy component, a governance term ("regulation", "AI policy", "workforce policy") and a jurisdiction term. Reference lists of the retrieved reviews will be searched backward, and forward citation tracking will be used on the most frequently cited items.

Inclusion and exclusion criteria

- Publication window 2019 to 2026, with earlier work admitted only where it establishes a conceptual framework still in use.

- Included: peer-reviewed articles; working papers issued by established research institutions; official statistical, regulatory, and legislative documents.

- Excluded: vendor marketing material, commentary without data or a stated method, and secondary reporting where the primary document is accessible.

- Where a claim rests on a non-English primary source, the original will be cited and the title given in transliteration with an English gloss.

Analytical instrument: a taxonomy of evidence

Each empirical statement presented in the literature review will be categorized into one of five categories depending on what is measured by the study it is based on:

- **Band 1:** projected exposure and model-based forecasts, which describe technical potential;

- **Band 2:** adoption, meaning whether firms report using AI;
- **Band 3:** observed use, meaning what users do with the technology in practice;
- **Band 4:** causal productivity effects established by field experiment within a single work application;
- **Band 5:** realized employment and wage outcomes from platform, payroll, or administrative data.

One of the figures will put each of the cited studies into its band so that the reader may easily understand that the largest figures from the literature come from the band which is farthest away from the observed outcomes. There will also be a glossary accompanying the paper where AI will be separated from generative AI, automatic decision-making systems, and algorithmic management; moreover, the task, occupation, and job will be separated as distinct units of analysis.

Case selection and comparative framework

Two examples of policies will be analyzed. Criteria for selection include the following: both cases are located at the frontier of technology and exhibit significant exposure to the innovation, hence any impacts on the labor market are likely to arise there first; both are democracies and have significant administrative capacity; and both have selected different types of instruments - either deployment conditions or adjustment funding. In California and South Korea these criteria hold. The two cases will be assessed against the same set of design factors in a single table: level of government, relevant instruments, nature of legal/policy tool, target group, mechanism, review and monitoring arrangements, existing evidence on outcomes, and constraints on implementation. Secondly, the two series of measures will be presented on the same timeline, with distinction made between instruments that are in effect and those that are announced/being considered.

Verification and quality control

- Every legal or programmatic claim will be checked against the text of the regulation, bill, or ministerial release rather than against secondary reporting.
- Each online source will carry an access date, and the review will declare a single information cut-off date after which no new developments are incorporated.
- Where a descriptive association is reported, rival explanations will be stated alongside it, and the data that would be needed to distinguish between them will be identified.
- Correlational cross-country policy evidence will not be presented as causal, and no instrument will be described as effective in the absence of outcome data.

Ethical considerations

The research does not involve any human subjects and personal information. Hence, no ethics review from an institution is necessary. Any use of AI software during literature search will be mentioned in the manuscript, but the responsibility of ensuring the accuracy and authenticity of the material remains solely on the author. The non-English source materials will be cited in their original language to prevent the misattribution of a statement to the government.

Work plan and expected outputs

- Months 1 to 2: protocol, search execution, screening, and construction of the evidence taxonomy.
- Months 3 to 4: synthesis of the empirical literature by band; drafting of the conceptual and evidential sections.
- Months 5 to 6: primary-source reconstruction of the two policy cases; completion of the comparison table and the timeline figure.
- Months 7 to 8: derivation of policy priorities, internal consistency check of every claim against its band label, and final revision.

The expected outcomes will include a review paper that will be in the range of 6,000 to 8,000 words, a comparative design chart, two figures, and a list of policies based on priority ranking where the rankings will depend on the quality of the evidence for each measure.

Research Topic

It is important because of the specificity, rather than generality, of the issue at hand. The argument by Acemoglu and Lensman is that interventions aimed at addressing the damages brought by a transformative technology will be disproportionately expensive if diffusion has already occurred [13]. AI diffusion is occurring at a pace faster than those of the previous technological waves, and yet policy development is happening at a pace of legislative sessions. The time frame in which preparation for such a transformation is still possible is relatively small and narrowing, especially as the inequalities generated by such displacement will be harder to mitigate once they occur.

The contribution is primarily methodological. Using the type of evidence as the basis of classification, as opposed to the magnitude of the estimation, is a rather uncommon approach for such research, and it is expected to have a profound effect on the outcome of the analysis – sorting the studies into different bands will allow to clear up the controversy between the projections and the almost non-existent administrative estimates, resulting in a narrower statement about the source of risk in AI. Combining the case of regulation/deployment with that of adjustment support is also done intentionally, as it allows posing the comparative question: does each of the two jurisdictions manage only one of the sources of risks, leaving the other underdeveloped?

The choice of time also helps to make use of those instruments which do not have any coverage in any review paper so far. These instruments include the California regulation on automated decision system, the privacy rules on automated decision-making technology, the veto and reintroduction of the No Robo Bosses Act, the executive order on workforce preparation, and the Korean Basic Plan for Industrial Transition Employment Stability which proposes an occupational exposure index and an early-warning dashboard which are all dated 2025 and 2026 [17] to [20]. The description of this set of instruments during their design period without any outcomes helps establish a baseline for evaluation of their outcomes.

The target readership is dual: the labor economists and policy researchers who require separating the evidence base, and the labor ministries, employment offices, and civil rights/privacy regulators who require designing the instruments before the evidence base can become available.

Quality of Writing

This proposal and its subsequent review have been composed in clear academic English with a multilingual audience in mind. Technical terms have been clearly identified upon first use, and any of those frequently confused in this discipline - namely exposure, adoption, automation, augmentation, and displacement - have been carefully distinguished and consistently used thereafter. All factual claims made have been related to their respective supporting sources and the kinds of evidence these sources provided, making the strength of each point apparent to the reader.

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